THE PITCH MANUAL

Everything needed at the keyboard, in the order the portal asks for it. Answers live whole in scratch/sbir-pitch/pitch-answers.txt - paste, never retype.

THE FORM, FIELD BY FIELD, IN ORDER

Step	What goes in
1. Portal + account	nsfgov.my.site.com/mywork → "Create an account" → first name, last name, email, password → Sign Up.
2. Start the pitch	Home → "SBIR/STTR Project Pitches" → "Submit New Project Pitch."
3. Company information	∞. Authorized company officer: Catherine Robinson-Rutella, Founder. US small business, majority US-citizen owned, no venture majority - **attested by her, Oct 23**.
4. Topic dropdown	**"Robotics and Autonomous Systems"** - the literal dropdown name; it routes the pitch to the right Program Director. Confirm the wording live on the form.
5. Question 1 - Technology Innovation	Paste answer 1. 2,045 of 3,500 characters.
6. Question 2 - Technical Objectives and Challenges	Paste answer 2. 2,341 of 3,500 characters.
7. Question 3 - Market Opportunity	Paste answer 3. 1,635 of 1,750 characters.
8. Question 4 - Company and Team	Paste answer 4. 1,562 of 1,750 characters.
9. Submit	One sitting. The form is editable only the same calendar day it is submitted. Screenshot the confirmation screen - that is the receipt.

The two open rulings, settled before step 3 if possible: (1) the "WA" expansion - hers, never guessed; (2) the topic wording if the live dropdown differs. Nothing else is open.

WHO READS IT, AND THEIR THREE QUESTIONS

One NSF Program Director reads the pitch - a domain expert, not a panel. They answer three questions, and the draft was built to answer each in order:

1. **Is there a real research question?** Ours: has anyone demonstrated a home-capable, human-experience humanoid at one-tenth to one-third the cost of commercial-grade systems? No. That unproven claim is the project.
2. **Is this team credible for this problem?** Ours: the 17-section specification, the costed BOM, 25 original papers, over 1,240 verifiable commits, and named specialist hires for Phase I.
3. **Will it matter commercially?** Ours: the home and care market no manufacturer serves - people with disabilities and aging-in-place first.

THE ONE DECLINE TRAP, NAMED

> The most common decline is a pitch that reads like a product, not a research question. NSF funds R&D where feasibility is unproven at project start - never "faster, cheaper, better." Our answers lead with the unknown and the method, and close with the market. Hold that shape if anything gets reworded live.

Second and third traps, already handled: overscoping (our four objectives are feasibility proof only - Phase I is not the prototype) and the wrong topic (the dropdown routes to the PD - step 4 is not a formality).

AFTER THE SUBMIT

Outcome	What it is	The play
Invitation	Email invitation to submit the full Phase I proposal	Real work starts: the mock proposal (ZYK-487) is the skeleton. Invitation valid for the next two submission deadlines under the solicitation.
Request for clarification	The PD wants more before deciding - a good sign	Respond promptly and specifically. Her call, drafted by me.
Decline with feedback	Brief explanation why	If framing: revise and resubmit (max two pitches per 12 months, three per project). If fit: call the PD - they will spend 15-20 minutes saying what a revised pitch needs.

Timing: expect the response in roughly 3-8 weeks (sources range 3-4 weeks to 1-2 months). Full-proposal deadlines: Nov 4, 2026 / March 4, 2027 / July 7, 2027 - the realistic target is March 4, 2027, backup July 7. The pitch itself goes in before November, at her word.

PRE-FLIGHT CHECKLIST

- ☐ Company paper settled: ∞; founder surface Cat Robinson-Rutella; eligibility "small business" attested (ruled Oct 23).
- ☐ "WA" expansion ruled, if it is going on the form.
- ☐ Answers file open: scratch/sbir-pitch/pitch-answers.txt - zero brackets, all four inside limits.
- ☐ MyWork account created and logged in.
- ☐ Topic dropdown confirmed: "Robotics and Autonomous Systems" (or exact live wording).
- ☐ Four answers pasted, in order, one sitting.
- ☐ Confirmation screen reached and screenshotted - the receipt lands in the record.
- ☐ SAM.gov registration started the same day, in parallel (free; needed for the full proposal, not the pitch; validation takes weeks).
- ☐ Nothing in the form references private family material - business surfaces carry business names only.

WHERE EVERYTHING LIVES

Artifact	Path
Paste-ready answers	scratch/sbir-pitch/pitch-answers.txt
Pitch scaffold + step plan	private-briefings/nsf-project-pitch-scaffold-ZYK-486-2026-10-23.html
Mock full proposal + KEY	private-briefings/nsf-phase1-mock-proposal-ZYK-487-2026-10-23.html (PDF twin in exports/)
Partnership prospectus	private-briefings/the-partner-pitch-ZYK-476-2026-10-23.html
Grants roadmap / collaborator paper	private-briefings/grants-roadmap-ZYK-410 / human-experience-humanoid-paper-ZYK-411
The portal	nsfgov.my.site.com/mywork

Submission is her hand, always. Every claim in the answers traces to a record receipt; counts read live off disk Oct 23, 2026. Field rules sourced: NSF 26-510 via SolicitFit (reviewed Oct 19, 2026), NSF's official Project Pitch Guide, and the Cada field-by-field guide (2026).